

Department of Physics: Financial Compliance & Procurement Policy

Internal Reference: PHYS-FIN-2026-V2

Applicability: All Principal Investigators (PIs), Postdocs, and Administrative Staff

1. Procurement and Purchasing Limits

To ensure compliance with institutional tax exemptions and internal auditing standards, the following rules apply to all departmental purchases, regardless of the external funding source (e.g., ERC, National Science Agencies):

1.1 IT and Computing Hardware

- **Preferred Vendors:** All computing hardware, including servers, workstations, RAM upgrades, and hard drives, must be purchased exclusively through the University's Central IT Procurement Portal.
- **Out-of-Pocket Reimbursements:** PIs and staff are strictly prohibited from purchasing IT hardware exceeding €500 using personal credit cards. Expense claims for hardware above this threshold will be automatically rejected by the Finance Office, even if the external grant allows the purchase.

1.2 Cloud Computing and Software Licenses

- **Central Billing:** Cloud infrastructure services (e.g., AWS, Google Cloud, Azure) must be routed through the University's centralized enterprise account to avoid Value Added Tax (VAT) surcharges.
- **Prohibited Methods:** Direct payment for cloud compute using departmental or personal credit cards is prohibited. A formal Purchase Order (PO) must be generated prior to spinning up cloud instances.

2. Travel and Conference Policies

2.1 Per Diem and Accommodation Limits

- The maximum allowable nightly hotel rate for domestic and European travel is €150. Any nightly rate exceeding this amount requires prior written approval from the Head of Department at least 14 days prior to travel.

- Conference registration fees must be paid directly via the University's purchasing card. Personal reimbursement for registration fees requires proof of transaction and a zero-balance invoice.

2.2 Student and Intern Travel

- Undergraduate students (including summer research interns) traveling for project-related field work or conferences must be accompanied by a senior researcher or have a signed risk-assessment form on file with the Departmental Safety Officer before booking travel.

3. Personnel and Hiring Approvals

3.1 Undergraduate Research Internships

- Undergraduate stipends must strictly adhere to the standard departmental rate of €400 per week. Stipends cannot be arbitrarily increased using surplus grant funds without authorization from the Dean of Sciences to prevent wage disparity among students.